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Online

Health Psychology Seminar 3:

Stress, Health, Coping and Adapting to Chronic Illness

Date



Overview of module

Unit	Topic	Assessment
1	Introduction to Health Psychology	
2	Understanding and Predicting Health Behaviours	
3	Health Promotion Interventions	CLQ poster and summary Peer responses Deadline:
4	Individual Differences	
5	Stress, Health and Coping	
6	Chronic Illness: Help-Seeking, Diagnosis, Adjustment	
7	Illness and Treatment Beliefs	
8	Psychological Processes at the End of Life	
9	The role of Psychology in Supporting Healthcare Professionals	Essay assignment: 2200 words: Deadline:



Recap Seminar 2

Health Promotion

Social Cognition Models

Individual differences

Poster assignment



Aims of the seminar

This week's seminar will focus on the relationship between stress and health. We will explore how stress can impact us physically, psychologically, and in our behaviour. We will also look at the pathway of chronic illness from diagnosis to adjustment and the importance of coping.

You should prepare in advance for these discussions using information from the core textbooks and recommended reading.

This week we will **test your knowledge on:**

1. Individual differences in the stress-health relationship. Why do some people get ill in response to stress and others don't?
2. Impact of a chronic illness diagnosis. What are the short-long term effects and how do individuals learn to adjust?



Question 1

Why do some people get ill in response to stress, and others don't?



What is stress?

Stress: collective physiological and emotional responses to any stimulus that disturbs an individual's **homeostasis**

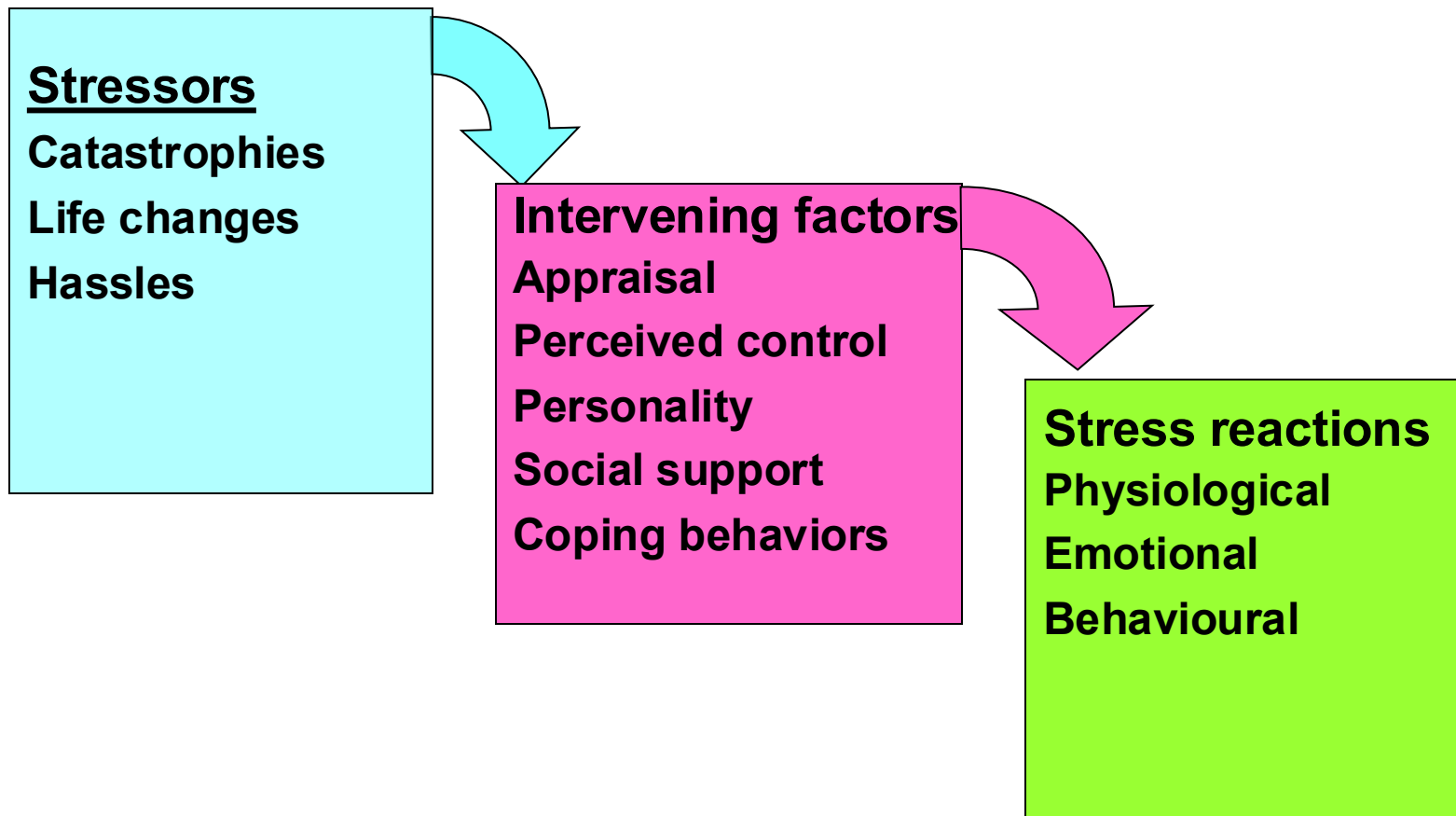
Stressor: an event that a person interprets as endangering their physical or psychological well-being

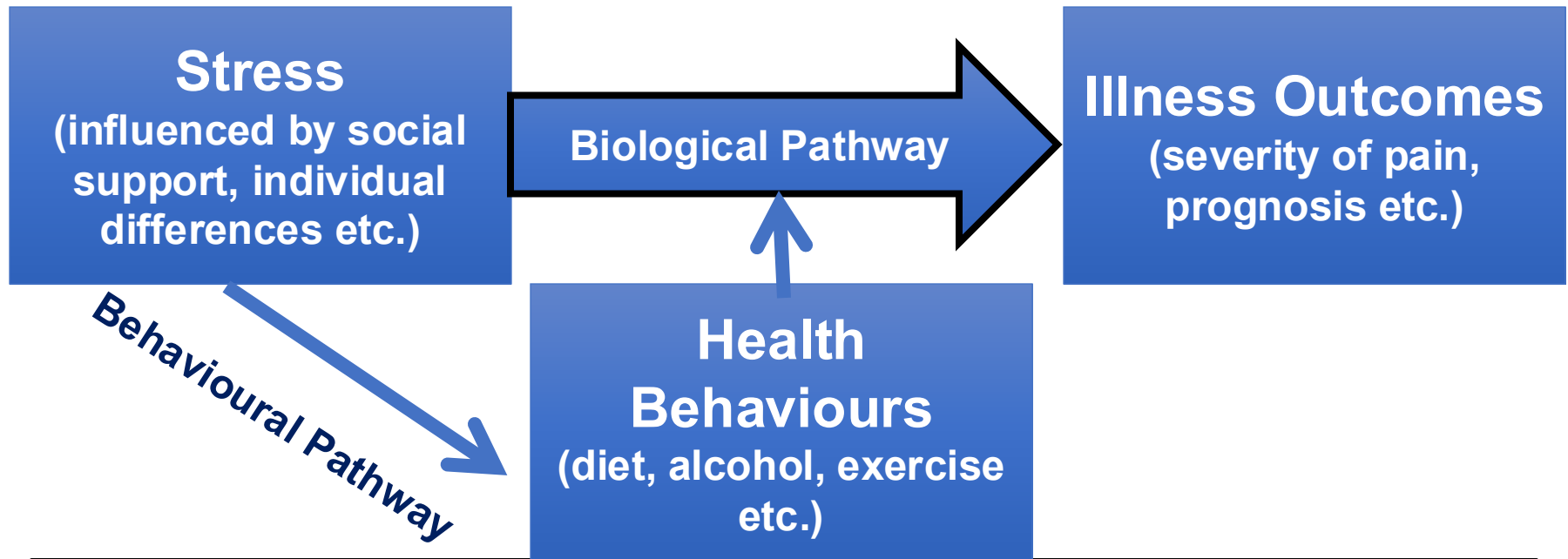
Stress response: reactions to the stressor

Stress is the state that occurs following the reaction to the stressor and stress response



Stressful situations





Biological pathway

- Stress exerts its effects via biological mechanisms e.g. immune system.

Behavioural pathway

- Stress exerts its effects via behavioural mechanisms e.g. negative health behaviours (smoking, poor nutrition, lack of exercise).

Short & long term health effects of stress

Morrison & Bennett, 2009 – pages 336-352

Short Term effects

Increased blood pressure,
increased clotting

Supressed digestion

Increased sugar levels in the
blood

Reduced stress hormones

Reduced growth hormones

Long term consequences

Heart attack, Stroke

Acid reflux, Obesity

Diabetes, Obesity, Vision
problems, Kidney disease

Low libido, Infertility

Premature ageing



Transactional model of stress

Lazarus & Folkman (1984) model notes the importance of interpretation

Three types of appraisal:

1. Primary
2. Secondary
3. Reappraisal

Suggest interpretation more important than the event itself
Describe stress as a relationship between the person and their environment (Rodham, 2010, pages 97-98)



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Does the Perception that Stress Affects Health Matter? The Association with Health and Mortality

Abiola Keller, Kristin Litzelman, Lauren E. Wisk, Torsheika Maddox, Erika Rose Cheng, Paul D. Creswell, and Whitney P. Witt

University of Wisconsin - Madison

Abstract

Objective—This study sought to examine the relationship among the amount of stress, the perception that stress affects health, and health and mortality outcomes in a nationally-representative sample of U.S. adults.

Methods—Data from the 1998 National Health Interview Survey were linked to prospective National Death Index mortality data through 2006. Separate logistic regression models were used to examine the factors associated with current health status and psychological distress. Cox proportional hazard models were used to determine the impact of perceiving that stress affects health on all-cause mortality. Each model specifically examined the interaction between the amount of stress and the perception that stress affects health, controlling for sociodemographic, health behavior, and access to healthcare factors.

Results—33.7% of nearly 186 million ($n=28,753$) U.S. adults perceived that stress affected their health a lot or to some extent. Both higher levels of reported stress and the perception that stress affects health were independently associated with an increased likelihood of worse health and mental health outcomes. The amount of stress and the perception that stress affects health



Question 2

What are the short-long term repercussions of chronic illness diagnosis and how do individuals learn to adjust?



Goals of coping

Cohen & Lazarus (1979) identified the following goals:

- Reduce stressful environmental conditions and maximise the chance of recovery
- Adjust to or tolerate negative events
- Maintain a positive self image
- Maintain emotional equilibrium
- Continue satisfying relationship with others



Coping Strategies

Problem-focused strategies:

Active coping

Planning

Instrumental social support

Suppression of competing activities

Emotion-focused strategies

Emotional social support

Venting emotions

Positive reinterpretation/growth

Behavioural disengagement

Mental disengagement



Coping with chronic illness

What may the **initial impact** be on the individual?

What type of **adjustments** will need to be made by the **individual** and **family**?

Article – ‘Adjusting life to chronic illness’

<https://www.bps.org.uk/psychologist/adjusting-life-chronic-illness>



Unit 6 looks at chronic illness: what is it, what is it like to be diagnosed with a chronic illness?

How can we adjust as individuals?

Lecturecast

Think of some examples of chronic illness ...



Impact of chronic illness on the Individual

Initial Impact may involve:

Shock, denial, loss, grief

Anxiety and depression

Must adjust to:

Symptoms of disease

Stress of treatment

Feelings of vulnerability and loss of control

Threat to self-esteem

Financial concerns

Changes in family structure



Impact on the Family

Adjustments may include:

- Increased stress

- Change in nature of their relationship

- Change in family structure/roles

- Lost income

Different issues for different relationships

- Young/Adult children of ill parents

- Spouse of ill person

- Parents of ill children



Crisis theory (Moos, 1982)

Model to describe factors that affect individuals' adjustment to serious illness

Based on idea that following a crisis psychological systems want to return to a state of equilibrium

Individuals are seen as self-regulators because they will find a way of returning to a stable state



Chronic illness as a crisis

Crisis

- Illness is a crisis because it is a turning point in an individual's life

Disruption

- **Disruption** to established patterns of personal and social functioning produces a state of psychological, social, and physical **disequilibrium**

Adaptation

- Finding new ways of coping with drastically altered circumstances to **restore equilibrium**



The role of the Health Psychologist

Support the process of adjustment

Study the influence of psychological and behavioral factor on illness course

Evaluate prevention and intervention programs

Develop strategies to improve compliance

Create support groups

Deal with psychological and behavioral repercussions (therapy)

Helping family members cope (therapy)

Sustaining of personal relationships



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Any questions?



End of Module essay



HPY July 2021

Participants

Grades

Module Home

Tutor Office

Deadline Details

Q & A Sessions

Module Resources

eBook

Unit 1

Unit 2

Unit 3

Unit 4

Unit 5

Behaviour Change Intervention Proposal Essay (2200 words)

Instructions

For this assignment, you are required to write an essay that will focus on one specific chronic illness (of your choosing) and to draw on psychological theory and current research to evidence your arguments.

Your proposal must address all of the following questions:

1. What is the impact of your selected chronic illness on the individual (including prevalence, adjustment, quality of life)?
2. What are the self-management challenges associated with your selected chronic illness, and can theoretical models tell us about the way individuals cope with chronic illness?
3. Critically evaluate current behaviour change interventions in your selected chronic illness.
4. Based on your understanding of theory, research and available interventions (covered in questions 1, 2, and 3), propose an intervention to promote optimal wellbeing in chronic illness.

Your proposal must demonstrate your ability to assimilate a range and depth of research knowledge and understanding of your selected illness and its impact. You should use appropriate psychological theories and research to support your proposal, and show the development of clear conclusions which are supported by evidence. Additionally, your proposal should be an effective critical evaluation and presentation of critical arguments related to the development of interventions.



Check your understanding

Question 1:

Why do some people get ill in response to stress and others don't?

Our past experience: Stress Diathesis Model

Dispositional coping style – resilience?

Our perception/appraisal

Emotional regulation

Social support



Check your understanding

Question 2:

What are the short-long term repercussions of a chronic illness diagnosis and how do individuals learn to adjust?

Shock, denial, symptom management

Uncertainty, identity/self-esteem, worry about future

Gradual acceptance of new life

Finding new ways of coping

Moos Crisis Theory

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Any questions?



Discuss and Debate

(a) To what extent can psychological factors influence health and illness processes?



Discuss and Debate

(b) What does research tell us about the barriers to successful adaptation of a chronic illness?



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Next Seminar date: